

What They Are, How to Stop, and More

 [healthline.com/health/how-to-stop-a-panic-attack](https://www.healthline.com/health/how-to-stop-a-panic-attack)

Ana Gotter

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Key takeaways

- Panic attacks manifest as sudden episodes of intense fear accompanied by physical and emotional symptoms, including difficulty breathing, sweating, trembling, and a sense of detachment.
- Various strategies can help manage panic attack symptoms, such as deep breathing exercises, mindfulness techniques, focusing on a specific object, and muscle relaxation exercises.
- Long-term prevention and management strategies include seeking counseling, particularly cognitive behavioral therapy (CBT), and, in some cases, using medication as prescribed by a doctor.

How to Stop a Panic Attack

Curious about how to stop a panic attack? This video shares 10 recommendations.

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[What do panic attacks feel like?](#)

[Panic attacks](#) are sudden, intense surges of fear, panic, or anxiety. They are overwhelming, and they have physical as well as emotional symptoms.

If you have a panic attack, you might have difficulty breathing, sweat profusely, tremble, and you may feel your heart pounding.

Some people will also experience chest pain and a feeling of detachment from reality or themselves during a panic attack, so they may think they're having a heart attack. Others have reported feeling like they're having a stroke.

They tend to start without warning, and symptoms reach a peak within minutes.

Panic attacks can be scary and may hit you quickly. Here are 12 strategies you can use to try to stop or manage panic attacks. Some may help you in the moment, while others can help in the longer term.

Therapy That's With You Through It All

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1. Seek counseling

[Cognitive-behavioral therapy \(CBT\)](#) and other types of counseling can often help people who have panic attacks and who have panic disorders. CBT aims to help you change the way you see challenging or frightening situations and to help you find new ways to approach these challenges as they arise.

As well as changing behavior, there's some evidence that CBT might affect structures in your brain that are responsible for panic symptoms.

[2018 research](#)[Trusted Source](#)[Trusted Source](#)[Trusted Source](#)[Trusted Source](#) found evidence that people who attended four weekly sessions of exposure-based CBT experienced changes in the neural pathways involved in panic symptoms. However, this was an early study, and more research is needed.

That said, CBT is not the only therapy modality that might help with anxiety, and it may not be the method that works best for you.

2. Take medications

[Benzodiazepines](#), such as alprazolam (Xanax), can help treat the symptoms of panic when they occur.

However, they won't help treat an underlying anxiety disorder and [can quickly lead](#) to dependence. For this reason, doctors only recommend them for short-term use during a crisis.

Because benzodiazepines are a prescription medication, you'll likely need a [panic disorder](#) diagnosis to have the medication on hand.

In some cases, a doctor may prescribe anti-depressants for long-term use. Some anti-seizure medications, such as pregabalin or clonazepam, can also help treat anxiety.

Boxed warning

Xanax has a [boxed warning](#)[Trusted Source](#)[Trusted Source](#)[Trusted Source](#)[Trusted Source](#) from the Food and Drug Administration (FDA) for physical dependence and withdrawal if you stop taking the drug suddenly. It can also lead to misuse and addiction.

Misuse of benzodiazepines increases your risk of overdose and death. Only take benzodiazepines as your doctor prescribes. Talk with your healthcare professional if you have any concerns about their safety.

A boxed warning is the strongest warning the FDA requires. It alerts doctors and patients about drug effects that may be dangerous.

3. Use deep breathing

While [hyperventilating](#) is a symptom of panic attacks that can increase fear, deep breathing can reduce symptoms of panic during an attack.

In one [study](#)[Trusted Source](#)[Trusted Source](#)[Trusted Source](#)[Trusted Source](#), published in 2017, 40 people joined either a therapy group that involved deep or diaphragmatic breathing or a control group. After 20 intensive training sessions, those who practiced deep breathing saw improvements in their attention levels and emotional well-being.

Try to focus on taking a deep breath through your nose, feeling the air slowly fill your chest and belly. Then slowly exhale through your mouth and feel the air leave your body. Breathe in through your nose for a count of 4, hold for 1 second, and then breathe out through your nose for a count of 4:

4. Recognize that you're having a panic attack

By recognizing that you're having a panic attack instead of a heart attack, you can remind yourself that this is temporary, it will pass, and that you're OK.

Try to set aside the fear that you may be dying or that impending doom is looming, both fears are only symptoms of panic attacks. This can allow you to focus on other techniques to reduce your symptoms.

5. Close your eyes

Some panic attacks come from triggers that overwhelm you. If you're in a fast-paced environment with a lot of stimuli, this can feed your panic attack.

To reduce the stimuli, [close your eyes](#) during your panic attack. This can block out any extra stimuli and make it easier to focus on your breathing.

6. Practice mindfulness

Mindfulness can help ground you in the reality of what's around you. Since panic attacks can cause a feeling of detachment or separation from reality, this can combat your panic attack as it's approaching or actually happening.

Mindfulness involves:

- focusing your attention on the present
- recognizing the emotional state you're in
- meditating to reduce stress and help you relax

[American Family Physician](#) recommends mindfulness as a strategy for dealing with panic and anxiety, saying it can be as helpful for reducing stress as CBT and other behavioral therapies.

7. Find a focus object

Some people find it helpful to find something to [focus all their attention](#) on during a panic attack. Pick one object in clear sight and consciously note everything you can about it.

For example, you may notice how the hand on the clock jerks when it ticks and that it's slightly lopsided. Describe the patterns, color, shapes, and size of the object to yourself. Focus all your energy on this object, and your panic symptoms may subside.

8. Use muscle relaxation techniques

Muscle tension is a symptom of anxiety and muscle relaxation techniques can help reduce tension and promote relaxation during an attack.

Progressive muscle relaxation aims to release tension in one group of muscles at a time to relax the whole body.

Much like deep breathing, muscle relaxation techniques can help stop your panic attack in its tracks by controlling your body's response as much as possible.

9. Picture your happy place

The place you visualize should be quiet, calm, and relaxing — no streets of New York or Hong Kong, no matter how much you love the cities in real life.

10. Engage in light exercise

[Research](#) published in 2021 shows that regular exercise may not only keep the body healthy but reduce your chance of developing anxiety.

If you're not used to exercising, talk with a doctor before starting. There's some [evidence](#)[Trusted Source](#)[Trusted Source](#)[Trusted Source](#)[Trusted Source](#) that starting aerobic exercise anew can trigger additional anxiety in people with an anxiety disorder.

Building up gradually can help your body adjust and avoid breathing problems. If you feel stressed or you're [hyperventilating](#) or struggling to breathe, stop and take a rest or choose a more moderate option, such as [walking](#), swimming, or yoga.

11. Keep lavender on hand

Lavender is a traditional remedy that many people use to reduce stress and help them relax.

[Older studies](#)[Trusted Source](#)[Trusted Source](#)[Trusted Source](#)[Trusted Source](#) suggest lavender has a calming effect but doesn't lead to dependence or cause withdrawal symptoms. Using products that contain diluted lavender essential oil may help reduce or manage symptoms of anxiety.

While research suggests there are health benefits, the FDA doesn't monitor or regulate the purity or quality of essential oils. It's important to talk with a healthcare professional before you begin using essential oils and be sure to research the [quality](#) of a brand's products. Always do a [patch test](#) before trying a new essential oil.

12. Repeat a mantra internally

Repeating a mantra internally can be relaxing and reassuring, and it can give you something to grasp onto during a panic attack.

Whether it's simply "This too shall pass," or a mantra that speaks to you personally, repeat it on a loop in your head until you feel the panic attack start to subside.

13. Talk with someone

Letting a friend, loved one, or even a colleague know that you're having a panic attack might help you feel less alone and more in control of your emotions.

Any trustworthy person in your vicinity can help calm you. It might be helpful to share ahead of time that you're prone to panic attacks so they know what to expect.

Even when in public, you can still flag down a person who might be able to assist you by taking you somewhere where there's less stimulation and staying with you as you calm down.

[Frequently asked questions](#)

What are the 3 symptoms of a panic attack?

If you have a panic attack, you [might experience](#) symptoms such as heart palpitations, [sweating](#), or difficulty breathing.

What causes panic attacks?

A panic attack often happens when you're exposed to a trigger, but triggers vary widely between people. In some cases, there may be no clear trigger.

Can you prevent a panic attack?

It's not always possible to prevent a panic attack, but certain [strategies](#) may help. Avoiding specific triggers may help prevent a panic attack, but this may not always be possible or appropriate. Some advice encourages people to "ride out" the attack and continue doing things, if possible.

[Summary](#)

Many people experience panic attacks, in which they suddenly feel anxious and not in control of a situation, possibly without knowing why.

You may feel breathless or as if you're having a heart attack, and it can be very frightening.

Panic attacks can occur unexpectedly and have a significant impact on your daily life, but there are ways to manage them. Treatment is also available for panic and anxiety disorders, which may be an underlying condition.

If you have concerns about panic attacks, speak with your doctor. They can help you work out a suitable strategy to manage symptoms and reduce the impact. This may involve medications, such as antidepressants, alongside counseling.

Explore online talk therapy options

